

Crime & Law

56 words · Crime & Law

NOUNS

crime

an illegal act punishable by law

Crime rates have fallen slightly in the last year.

witness

a person who sees a crime or event take place

The witness described the suspect to the police.

evidence

information or objects used to prove something in a legal case

The DNA evidence was crucial to securing the conviction.

fine

a sum of money paid as a punishment for breaking a law

She got a two-hundred-euro fine for speeding.

punishment

a penalty imposed for breaking a law or rule

The punishment should fit the crime.

bribery

the act of offering money or favours to influence someone's behaviour

Bribery of public officials carries a prison sentence.

bail

money paid to release an accused person from custody until trial

He was released on bail pending a full hearing.

recidivism

the tendency of a convicted criminal to reoffend

Recidivism rates remain stubbornly high despite reform efforts.

victim

a person who has been harmed by a crime or accident

The victim was taken to hospital with minor injuries.

suspect

a person believed to have committed a crime

Police arrested a suspect within hours of the robbery.

sentence

the punishment given to someone found guilty of a crime

He received a five-year prison sentence.

robbery

the crime of stealing from a person or place using force or threat

There was an armed robbery at the bank on the high street.

fraud

the crime of deceiving someone for financial or personal gain

He was charged with fraud after faking his qualifications.

verdict

the decision of a jury or judge at the end of a trial

The jury reached a verdict of not guilty.

deterrent

something that discourages someone from committing a crime

Longer sentences are not always an effective deterrent.

rehabilitation

helping someone reintegrate into society after prison

For dangerous people, prison works, but for minor offences, rehabilitation makes more sense.

ADJECTIVES

guilty

responsible for committing a crime; proven to have broken the law

The jury found him guilty on all charges.

illegal

against the law; not permitted

It's illegal to drive without insurance.

white-collar

relating to non-violent crime committed by business or professional people

White-collar crime often goes unpunished compared to street crime.

innocent

not guilty of a crime

He was found innocent after new evidence came to light.

juvenile

relating to young people, especially those who commit crimes

Juvenile crime has become a growing concern in urban areas.

VERBS

steal

to take something that belongs to someone else without permission

Someone stole her phone on the metro.

acquit

to formally declare someone not guilty of a criminal charge

She was acquitted of all charges due to lack of evidence.

arrest

to take someone into police custody for a suspected crime

He was arrested on suspicion of fraud.

plead

to say in court whether you did or did not commit a crime

He pleaded guilty to the lesser charge.

PHRASAL VERBS

break into

to enter a building illegally, usually by force

Someone broke into the office over the weekend.

turn oneself in

to surrender to the police voluntarily

He turned himself in after three days on the run.

lock up

to put someone in prison

He was locked up for eight years for armed robbery.

let off

to give someone little or no punishment

He was let off with a warning for his first offence.

get away with

to avoid punishment for something wrong or illegal

He lied on his CV and got away with it for years.

crack down on

to take severe measures against illegal activity

Police have cracked down on knife crime in the area.

cover up

to hide evidence of wrongdoing or a crime

The company tried to cover up the safety violations.

COLLOCATIONS

commit a crime

to carry out an illegal act

He committed the crime in broad daylight.

petty crime

minor, non-violent crime like shoplifting or vandalism

Petty crime, maybe. But violent crime has actually dropped in most countries.

broad daylight

in the middle of the day, in plain view

Yes, broad daylight, apparently. They got away with it too.

miscarriage of justice

a failure of the legal system that results in a wrongful conviction or unjust outcome

New DNA evidence eventually overturned what campaigners had long called a miscarriage of justice.

criminal record

an official record of a person's past criminal convictions, held by the police or government

It's hard to get certain jobs if you have a criminal record.

petty theft

the stealing of small amounts of money or low-value goods

Petty theft, like shoplifting, is usually dealt with through fines rather than prison.

burden of proof

the duty to prove an accusation or claim, which in criminal cases lies with the prosecution

The burden of proof lies with the prosecution, not the defendant.

white-collar crime

non-violent crime committed by professionals, such as fraud

It's rarely punished properly. People behind bars for theft while fraudsters walk free.

IDIOMS

caught red-handed

caught in the act of doing something wrong

She was caught red-handed shoplifting from the supermarket.

above the law

not subject to the same rules as everyone else

Nobody should be above the law, regardless of their status.

throw the book at someone

to punish someone as severely as the law allows

The judge threw the book at him, handing down the maximum sentence.

a slippery slope

a course of action that seems small but leads to serious consequences

Bending the rules even slightly is a slippery slope.

fall foul of the law

to break the law and get into trouble as a result

The company fell foul of the law after ignoring the new safety regulations.

behind bars

in prison

He spent ten years behind bars before being released.

take the law into your own hands

to punish someone yourself instead of calling the police

You can't take the law into your own hands, however angry you are.

get off scot-free

to escape punishment or blame completely

Despite everyone knowing he was involved, he got off scot-free on a technicality.

the long arm of the law

the far-reaching power of the legal system

You can run, but the long arm of the law will catch up with you.

SET PHRASES

case closed

used to say that a matter is now settled and needs no further discussion or investigation

*The suspect confessed and the evidence matched.
Case closed.*

you have the right to remain silent

the fixed phrase used to tell a suspect they are not obliged to answer police questions

The officer read him his rights: 'You have the right to remain silent.'

I plead not guilty

the fixed phrase a defendant uses in court to formally deny the charge against them

He stood up and said I plead not guilty, so it's heading to a full trial now.

I swear to tell the truth, the whole truth, and nothing but the truth

the fixed oath a witness recites before giving evidence in court

She stood in the witness box and said, 'I swear to tell the truth, the whole truth, and nothing but the truth.'

MODERN SLANG

copper

a police officer (British informal)

Two coppers were waiting outside the shop when the alarm went off.

grass

to inform the police about someone's criminal activity (British informal)

Someone grassed on him and he got arrested the next day.

dodgy

suspicious, dishonest, or of poor quality (British informal)

The whole deal sounded dodgy. I wouldn't trust him.